longer viable. Nonetheless, the boom years had given Bombay a new status and a speculative spirit that remains very much alive to this day. Strike up a conversation with the street vendors of Nariman Point or the Fort, and you are likely to be given stock-market tips aplenty (although I would be somewhat wary of investing on the basis of this advice).

MAPPING TIBET

By the 1860s, the British surveyors had an accurate map of the subcontinent and were beginning to wonder what lay beyond the Himalayas. This was no idle curiosity; it was driven by Russian inroads into Central Asia. The 'Great Game' had begun. The problem was that the Tibetan authorities were not keen to let in Europeans inside their borders—a few who had tried had been tortured and killed. The Survey of India decided to use Indian spies disguised as traders and pilgrims. The first and most famous of these was a young schoolteacher from the Kumaon hills, Nain Singh. In 1865, he crossed from Nepal into Tibet along with a party of traders. A few days after the crossing, the traders slipped away one night with most of Nain Singh's money and left him stranded in a strange land.

Fortunately, they had left behind his most valuable possessions, concealed in a box with a false bottom—a sextant, a thermometer, a chronometer, a compass and a container of mercury. He also had a Buddhist rosary, except it had 100 beads instead of the usual 108. Nain Singh planned to measure distance by slipping one bead for every 100 paces walked. He also had a prayer wheel that concealed slips of paper on which he recorded compass bearings and distances [18] .

Nain Singh somehow begged his way across the cold and desolate landscape. In January 1865, he finally entered the forbidden city of Lhasa. He took care to behave in a manner appropriate for a pilgrim, including making a brief visit to the Dalai Lama of that time. Meanwhile, he supported himself by teaching local merchants the Indian system of keeping accounts. His position, however, was very precarious. This was brought home when he witnessed the beheading of a Chinese man who had arrived